

Giving Empathetic Feedback

10-Week Leadership Development Program

Daily Habit	Weekly Deliverable	Reading
Before any feedback conversation, ask yourself two questions: (1) Do I genuinely care about this person? (2) Am I challenging them to grow, or just criticizing?	Have one Radical Candor feedback conversation. Afterward, ask: 'Was that clear and helpful?'	Radical Candor: Be a Kick-Ass Boss Without Losing Your Humanity — Chapters 1–4 (Kim Scott)

Core Concept

Kim Scott's framework identifies four quadrants of feedback based on two dimensions: how much you care personally about the person, and how directly you challenge them.

Ruinous Empathy: You care but don't challenge. You soften feedback until it loses meaning. The person doesn't improve and you've done them a disservice. Obnoxious Aggression: You challenge directly but don't show you care. Feedback lands as an attack, not a gift. Manipulative Insincerity: You neither care nor challenge honestly. Backstabbing, politics, vague praise. Radical Candor: You care deeply AND you challenge directly. You say the hard thing because you want the person to succeed.

The failure mode most leaders fall into is Ruinous Empathy — being too nice, too vague, too worried about hurting feelings. But a doctor who doesn't tell you about the tumor because they don't want to upset you is not being kind.

""Caring personally is the antidote to the freeze, fight, or flight response. Challenge directly is the willingness to say what needs to be said.""

— Kim Scott

Framework: The Radical Candor 2x2

Before giving feedback, locate yourself:

Care Personally
HIGH

Empathy | Candor

Manipulative | Obnoxious

LOW

Feedback formula: '[Specific situation] + [Observable behavior] + [Impact] + [What I'd like to see]'

- The 2-question pre-check: Before feedback, ask: (1) Do I care about this person's growth? (2) Am I challenging them enough to actually help?
- Specific > general: Replace 'you need to communicate better' with 'In yesterday's meeting, when you gave the update, I noticed you skipped the timeline section — that left the team confused about next steps.'
- Immediate feedback: Deliver feedback as close to the event as possible. Waiting makes it harder to be specific and makes the person wonder why you didn't say something sooner.
- Ask for feedback: At the end of a feedback conversation, ask 'Was that helpful? Was I clear?' This models the behavior you're asking for.

Scenario 1

A high-potential team member repeatedly shows up late to client meetings. You've noticed it three times but haven't said anything because you don't want to discourage them.

Reflection: Write out what you would say using the Radical Candor formula.

Scenario 2

Your direct report delivers a presentation that is technically correct but puts the audience to sleep. Your manager pulls you aside to ask what happened.

Reflection: How do you give this feedback in a way that develops rather than deflates?

Weekly Reflection Prompts

Set aside 20 minutes at the end of this week to write your responses. These are for you — be honest.

Reflection 1: Where do you tend to fall on the 2x2? Ruinous empathy, obnoxious aggression, or something else?

Reflection:

Reflection 2: Think of a piece of feedback you've been withholding. What story have you been telling yourself about why you haven't given it yet?

Reflection:

Reflection 3: Who gave you the most useful feedback you've ever received? What made it land? What can you learn from how they delivered it?

Reflection:

Weekly Habit Tracker

Day	Done?	Notes / Observations
Monday	■	
Tuesday	■	
Wednesday	■	
Thursday	■	
Friday	■	
Saturday	■	
Sunday	■	

End-of-Week Summary

Reflection: What was my biggest leadership learning this week?

Reflection: What will I carry forward into next week?

Reflection: One relationship I invested in this week: